

If you don't want to spend your time drawing complex mind maps (or if your handwriting is worse than your family doctor's), you can dump your thoughts using FreeMind - a free, open source mind-mapping tool that gives you all you need to create huge mind maps, and make them look good enough to use as presentations, too.

9.1 The Mind-mapper's Primer



An example of a mind map

When you're working on an idea or task, your brain doesn't make neat bulleted lists to gather your thoughts - it starts at a central goal or theme, and many trains of thought burst forth from there. An upcoming presentation starts you thinking about your audience, which in turn starts you thinking about what would appeal to them, and it snowballs from there. To capture all this on paper (or screen, for that matter), you draw a mind map. Start with your central theme; this could be the theme for your next team meeting, a task you have to accomplish, or anything else that warrants considerable thought. Then jot down the first thing you think about it right next to it, and any more thoughts that occur to you in the same vein. Repeat for each thought. The example below, and the pages that follow, should be more illustrative:

9.2 Getting Started With FreeMind

FreeMind's user interface is simple enough - the toolbar at the top gives you basic control over the application: open mind maps, create new ones, format text and so on. The toolbar on the left is full of icons that you can use in your mind maps - we'll come to those in a bit.